

NT42 Enrichment

†1. **Who wrote James?:** “The epistle states that it was authored by “James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ” (James 1:1). Christian tradition has held that this James, like Jude, is one of the sons of Joseph and Mary and hence half-brother of Jesus of Nazareth (see Matthew 13:55; Mark 6:3; Galatians 1:19). The fact that James is mentioned first in the list of Jesus’s brothers in Matthew 13:55 may indicate that he was the oldest of the half-brothers. Like the Lord’s other half-brothers, James did not initially become a disciple of Jesus (see John 7:3–5). However, after Jesus was resurrected, James was one of those special individuals to whom Christ appeared as a resurrected Being (see 1 Corinthians 15:7). Later James became an Apostle and, according to early Christian writers, the first bishop of the Church in Jerusalem (see Acts 12:17; 21:18; Galatians 1:18–19; 2:9). As a leader in the Church, he played a prominent role in the council held in Jerusalem (Acts 15:13). His influence in the Church was no doubt strengthened by his kinship to Jesus, yet he showed humility in introducing himself not as the brother of Jesus but as a servant of the Lord (see James 1:1). For further information on James, see the commentary for Acts 15:13–29.” (*New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212*, [Chapter 50: James](#))

†2. **Spencer W. Kimball:** “In abandoning evil, transforming lives, changing personalities, molding characters or remolding them, we need the help of the Lord, and we may be assured of it if we do our part. The man who leans heavily upon his Lord becomes the master of self and can accomplish anything he sets out to do, whether it be to secure the brass plates, build a ship, overcome a habit, or conquer a deep-seated transgression.

“He who has greater strength than Lucifer, he who is our fortress and our strength, can sustain us in times of great temptation. While the Lord will never forcibly take anyone out of sin or out of the arms of the tempters, he exerts his Spirit to induce the sinner to do it with divine assistance. And the man who yields to the sweet influence and pleadings of the Spirit and does all in his power to stay in a repentant attitude is guaranteed protection, power, freedom and joy.” (*Miracle of Forgiveness*, p176)

†3. **Lloyd D. Newell:** “When we approach the ‘rough’ in life with a positive attitude and a humble dependence upon God, it is amazing how the rocky road we were once traveling can become so much more smooth. The nature of ‘the road’ really does not change, but our capacity to walk it increases when we turn to God for support. We, like Paul, will then say to ourselves: ‘I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me.’” (*The Divine Connection*, p. 06))

†4. **President Joseph F. Smith on pure religion:** “This may be interpreted as meaning that a person who is religious is thoughtful to the unfortunate, and has an inner spirit that prompts to deeds of kindness and to the leading of a blameless life; who is just, truthful; who does not, as Paul says, think more highly of himself than he ought to think; who is affectionate, patient in tribulation, diligent, cheerful, fervent in spirit, hospitable, merciful; and who abhors evil and cleaves to that which is good. The possession of such a spirit and feeling is a true sign that a person is naturally religious.

“The Church’s outward ordinances and requirements are but necessary—yet they are necessary—aids to the inner spiritual life. The Church itself, the organization, meetings, ordinances, requirements, are only helps, but very necessary helps, to the practice of true religion—schoolmasters to direct us in the way of eternal light and truth.” (*Gospel Doctrine*, p121)

†5. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell on James 1:1-4; 5:10-11:** “Can we expect to become like Him, given our imperfections, unless we can learn to accept and apply needed reproof and correction ...? How essential our capacity to receive correction and reproof is, for ‘he that refuseth instruction despiseth his own soul: but he that heareth reproof getteth understanding.’ (Prov. 15:32) Deserved self-esteem depends upon our meekness.

“In our personal development, the emery wheel of events can polish us, and the sandpaper of circumstances can smooth us. Too often, when so worked upon, we grow fearful instead of being trusting and submissive. But Peter overcame his fearfulness, and so can we.” (*Even As I Am*, p.63; cited in Ted L. Gibbons, [New Testament Sunday School Lesson 42: “Pure Religion”](#) at LDSLiving, October 29, 2015.)

†6. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell on James 1:1-4; 5:10-11:** “In life, the sandpaper of circumstances often smooths our crustiness and patiently polishes our rough edges. There is nothing pleasant about it, however. And the Lord will go to great lengths in order to teach us a particular lesson and to help us to overcome a particular weakness, especially if there is no other way. In such circumstances, it is quite useless for us mortals to try to do our own sums when it comes to suffering. We can’t make it all add up because clearly we do not have all the numbers. Furthermore, none of us knows much about the algebra of affliction. The challenges that come are shaped to our needs and circumstances, sometimes in order to help our weaknesses become strengths. Job noted how tailored his challenges were, saying, “For the thing which I greatly feared has come upon me, and that which I was afraid of is come unto me” (Job 3:25). Yet he prevailed so much so that he was held up as a model to the great latter-day prophet, Joseph Smith. (D&C 121.)” (*Notwithstanding My Weakness*, p.67-68; cited in Ted L. Gibbons, [New Testament Sunday School Lesson 42: “Pure Religion”](#) at LDSLiving, October 29, 2015.)

†7. **Ted L. Gibbons story about a man's prayer:**

"Many years ago I shared the gospel with a couple from Puerto Rico. The wife received a testimony during the first visit. The husband, however, had no such witness. He fasted and he prayed and he listened to the rest of the discussions over a period of several weeks, but no manifestations came. He said again and again to us that he did not know.

"Then, one Sunday, after a wonderful sacrament meeting, he walked to the front of the chapel and asked the Bishop to arrange for his baptism. The bishop, who was well aware of his previous reticence, called us forward and then asked what had happened. In the discussion that followed, we learned the following.

"John had prayed for weeks for a testimony, but, he said, always with this thought in mind: *Once I know if it is true, then I will make a decision about what to do.*

"He was praying without real intent. He was, to use the words of James, "double minded." But during sacrament meeting he had felt something and speakers had spoken to his heart with answers to questions he had been discussing with his wife the evening before. He said that during the closing prayer of the meeting he had offered his own prayer: this one: *'Lord, if you want me to be baptized, tell me now and I will get up and do it.'* He said that before he could stand up, he knew. The answer came liberally because he had prayed with real intent." (In [New Testament Sunday School Lesson 42: "Pure Religion"](#) at LDSLiving, October 29, 2015.)

†8. **Ted L. Gibbons story about another man's**

prayer: "Another example of this approach to prayer comes from my book called *Put Off Thy Shoes*.

"It was family reunion time and they were heading for Utah from a small community in northeastern Arizona. As they passed through Flagstaff, they stopped at a department store to purchase some supplies. The father, acting on what he described later as a whim, decided to buy a pocket knife. He had never carried one, and had no need to do so now, but the inclination was there, and he made the purchase.

"Many miles later on the reservation, and some distance from Cameron, the car began suddenly to shudder and vibrate. They stopped and the father opened the hood where the problem seemed to originate. He was not a mechanical wizard. He could point out the engine, the radiator, and the battery, but that was about all. In fact, he carried no tools in the car because he would not know what to do with them if they were needed.

"It was a sweltering day, the temperature near one hundred degrees. The car held the family; dad, mom, and six kids. He did not know what to do. Another attempt to drive the car simply reinforced their dilemma. Whatever was wrong was still wrong. He explained the problem to the family. Diane, his wife, was the first to suggest prayer. They all bowed their heads. No one remembers the words, nor any particular feeling during the prayer. But when it was over, the father walked once again to the front of the car and surveyed the engine

compartment. An impression came then. *Cut that belt.* And he knew which one.

"He looked long at it. It connected two pulleys fastened to pieces of equipment whose purpose he could not conceive. As he regarded it, the impression persisted. He leaned through the open window of the car and told his wife what he was feeling.

"There was simply no way to know in advance the consequences of the act. It was frightening. In the several minutes they had been stopped, only one car had passed, without slowing. If cutting the belt disabled the car completely, their situation would be terribly difficult.

"It was the knife that gave him the courage to proceed. On any other trip, such an impression would have been meaningless. He would have had no way to cut the belt. He reflected a moment on the coincidence of the purchase of that knife and an impression to use it. Then he opened a blade and cut the belt. He started the engine; the shaking had ceased.

"They stopped in Cameron thirty-five minutes later, and talked to a mechanic. The belt had something to do with the air conditioner. By cutting the belt, he had disconnected a worn out bearing. Without it, the trip might be a bit more uncomfortable, but the car would be fine." (In [New Testament Sunday School Lesson 42: "Pure Religion"](#) at LDSLiving, October 29, 2015.)

†9. **Ted L. Gibbons quotes Brigham Young' regarding the day survivors of the tragic handcart companies arrived in the Salt Lake Valley:** "The scriptures also tell us that we are saved not by our own righteousness but by the righteousness of our Redeemer (see 2 Nephi 2:3; D&C 45:3-5).

And that understanding is inherent in the language of James. But so many of our faithful Christian brethren have missed the point. Brigham Young taught it powerfully to the saints in Salt Lake one Sunday afternoon when he was informed that the survivors of an ill-fated handcart company, who had suffered so much in the snows and weather of Wyoming, were about to arrive. The Salt Lake saints were assembled that morning in the Tabernacle. Brigham Young said:

The afternoon meeting will be omitted, for I wish the sisters to go home and prepare to give those who have just arrived a mouthful of something to eat, and to wash them and nurse them up. You know that I would give more for a dish of pudding and milk, or a baked potato and salt, were I in the position of those persons who have just come in, than I would for all your prayers, though you were to stay here all the afternoon and pray. Prayer is good, but when baked potatoes and pudding and milk are needed, prayer will not supply their place . . . (Reported in the *Salt Lake Deseret News*, December 10, 1856, p. 320.)

†10. Dallin H. Oaks: “Profane and vulgar expressions are public evidence of a speaker’s ignorance, inadequacy, or immaturity.”

“A speaker who profanes must be ignorant or indifferent to God’s stern command that his name must be treated with reverence and not used in vain.

“A speaker who mouths profanity or vulgarity to punctuate or emphasize speech confesses inadequacy in his or her own language skills. Properly used, modern languages require no such artificial boosters.

“A speaker who employs profanity or vulgarity to catch someone’s attention with shock effect engages in a babyish device that is inexcusable as juvenile or adult behavior. Such language is morally bankrupt. It also progressively self-defeating, since shock diminishes with familiarity and the user can only maintain its effect by escalating its excess.

“Members of the Church, young or old, should never allow profane or vulgar words to pass their lips. The language we use projects the images of our hearts, and our hearts should be pure...” (“[Reverent and Clean](#),” *Ensign*, May 1986.)

Recommended Reading:

1. Ted L. Gibbons, [New Testament Sunday School Lesson 42: “Pure Religion”](#) at LDSLiving, October 29, 2015.

2. Nancy Jensen, [New Testament Lesson #42 "Pure Religion"](#), LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, October 7, 2011. Nancy presents a wonderful metaphor of Ricks Spring in Logan Canyon and “purity”.

3. Taylor Halverson, [Lesson 42: “pure Religion”](#), October 19, 2015. Taylor presents a table that shows all of James’ teachings in a convenient format.

4. Ben Spackman, [Gospel Doctrine Lesson 42 – James \(updated\)](#), in Benjamin the Scribe, November 8, 2015. Ben presents a couple of inspiring quotes in his post.

Recommended Conference Talks:

Robert D. Hales, “[Waiting upon the Lord: Thy Will Be Done](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.

Quentin L. Cook, “[The Songs They Could Not Sing](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.

J. Devin Cornish, “[The Privilege of Prayer](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.

Jeffrey R. Holland, “[The Tongue of Angels](#),” *Ensign*, May 2007.

Sylvia Allred, “[The Essence of Discipleship](#),” *Ensign*, May 2011.

Lynn G. Robbins, “[What Manner of Men and Women Ought Ye to Be?](#)” *Ensign*, May 2011.